

Watch Commander Ops Hub

Fire Service Go-to-Market Strategy

Prepared for internal use — a working document for pitching the Ops Hub to UK Fire & Rescue Services.

Executive Summary

Watch Commander Ops Hub is an operational management platform built by a serving Watch Commander for UK fire stations. It replaces the paper, spreadsheets, and WhatsApp workflows that currently run daily watch operations — crewing boards, handover notes, sickness tracking, certification monitoring, and audit trails.

Tagline: *"Stop managing your watch from a clipboard."*

Core value proposition: A single source of truth for everything a watch needs to run safely, with a full audit trail for HMICFRS compliance and zero on-premises infrastructure.

1. Who to Target

Approach bottom-up, not top-down. Get serving staff using it informally, then escalate with evidence.

Audience	Why Them	How to Reach
Watch Commanders (peers)	Peer validation matters more than slick decks. Your credibility as a serving WC is the biggest asset.	Coffee on station, WhatsApp groups, brigade conferences
Station/Group Managers	They feel the pain of chasing paper crewing boards, sickness cover, and handover gaps	Informal demo — "Boss, look what I built"
Area Managers / Heads of Service Support	Own the digital transformation budget and HMICFRS readiness	Formal proposal once you have SM/GM buy-in
ICT / Digital / InfoSec	Gatekeepers for any tool touching personnel data	Security architecture doc, DPIA

First move: Get one more watch on your own station using it before approaching anyone above you.

2. The Hook — Problems You're Solving

Lead with pain points already complained about daily:

- **"Who's on OIC B10P1 on the 15th?"** — currently requires ringing around or digging through emails
- **"Prove to HMICFRS who signed off that crewing board"** — currently impossible or very slow
- **"Find me everyone with a BA re-qualification expiring in 30 days"** — currently a manual audit
- **"What did Red Watch hand over to White Watch last shift?"** — currently a whiteboard photo on WhatsApp
- **"We had a sickness gap on 1st pump and nobody spotted it until the bells went"** — genuine operational risk

If a decision-maker recognises any of those problems, you have their attention.

3. Unfair Advantages

Lead with these. They're what makes this product different from generic HR or rota tools.

1. **Built by a serving Watch Commander.** Not a consultant who "interviewed firefighters" — someone who actually drives a pump and fills in the book. Worth more than any feature list.
 2. **Designed around the real workflow.** Day/night shift types, change of shift, detached duties, rest days, leave — all the messy reality generic rota tools ignore.
 3. **HMICFRS-ready audit trail.** Every crewing decision logged with actor, timestamp, and full context. Inspectors love this.
 4. **GDPR-compliant by design.** Role-based access control (WC/CC/FF), encrypted in transit (HSTS), rate-limited auth, strict content security policy. All documented.
 5. **No on-prem headache.** Cloud-hosted. No server in the back office to maintain.
 6. **Works on a phone.** PWA (Progressive Web App) — station iPad, WC's phone, office desktop — all the same app.
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4. Proof Points

Evidence beats rhetoric every time. Build up a library of:

- **Live demo on real watch data** (anonymised if needed) — people buy what they can see working
- **Audit log screenshots** — "Here's every decision on yellow watch for the last 30 days, one click"
- **Sickness gap detection example** — "This alert fired at 06:00 today before parade because a sick entry crossed today's crewing board"
- **Before/after metrics from your own watch:**
 - Hours saved per week on admin

- Reduction in crewing errors
- Faster handover completion
- Certifications flagged before expiry

Start collecting these numbers now. "Time spent on crewing before and after" is the killer stat.

5. Commercial Model

Three realistic options, easiest to hardest to land:

Model	Pros	Cons
Per-station SaaS (e.g. £50–£200/month)	Predictable revenue, scales, low barrier to entry	Procurement cycles can be 12+ months
Per-brigade licence (£20k–£80k/year)	Big ticket, brigade-wide adoption	Requires FBU/union conversation, long procurement
Free + consulting for deployment/customisation	Frictionless adoption, trust-building	You do the work, harder to scale

Recommended starting point: Offer free or heavily discounted pilots (£50/month per station) for the first 2–3 stations. Gather adoption evidence and ROI metrics. Then approach brigade HQ with *proof of adoption*, not just a pitch.

Retrofit a proper per-brigade deal once you're embedded.

6. Objections and Responses

Pre-empt the questions you'll hear in every meeting.

Objection	Your Answer
"We already have FireWatch / GRS / Pulsar"	"Those are MIS systems — they hold the records. This is the daily operational layer — crewing, handover, real-time alerts. It sits between the MIS and the watch."
"What about data security?"	Show CSP, HSTS, rate-limiting, RBAC. Offer a pen-test report once you have one commissioned.
"Who supports it at 3am?"	"Cloud-hosted, monitored with Sentry error tracking, automatic failover. Better uptime than most current MIS systems."
"This is a single point of failure"	"The paper clipboard is also a single point of failure — one spilt coffee and it's gone. This has backups and a full audit trail."
"It's not on our approved supplier list"	"Happy to fill out your InfoSec questionnaire and DPIA. Let's find out what's needed to get on the list."
"Will the FBU have concerns?"	"It's an operational tool, not a performance-monitoring tool. The audit log shows <i>decisions</i> , not individual productivity."
"What about integration with [existing system]?"	"Read-only integrations possible via API. We're not asking to replace your system of record — we're the operational layer above it."

7. First 30 Days Plan

Week	Goal	Actions
Week 1	Prove it on your own watch	Full pilot with your own watch. Collect baseline metrics. Note specific time savings.
Week 2	Get one more watch on board	Show it to the other watches at your station. Offer to help set them up. Get at least one more using it daily.
Week 3	Your Station Manager	20-minute demo. Come armed with data ("two watches now, X hours saved/week, here's the audit log").
Week 4	Escalation path	Ask SM who at GM/AM level is interested in digital tools. Get introduced — don't cold-email.

Don't do this: Email AMs/DCFOs cold with a pitch deck. It'll die in their inbox. **Do this:** Walk in with a serving WC and say "Boss, look at this, we've been using it for a month."

8. Supporting Documents to Prepare

Before you approach anyone at brigade HQ, have these ready:

1. **One-page summary** — decision-makers read one page, not ten
 2. **2-minute demo video** — for sharing in WhatsApp groups, emails, pre-meeting links
 3. **Security & data protection overview** — for ICT/InfoSec (most of this already exists in the codebase)
 4. **DPIA (Data Protection Impact Assessment) template** — fire services will require this for personnel data
 5. **HMICFRS mapping document** — map features to HMICFRS inspection criteria: - Efficient use of resources - Promoting workforce planning - Ensuring fairness and promoting diversity - Leading and developing staff
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9. Risks to Flag Internally

Be honest about these rather than letting them be discovered later.

- **Single developer key-person risk** — need a plan for handover or backup support
 - **Scaling beyond one brigade** — current infrastructure supports it, but SLAs and support hours would need to scale too
 - **Union/FBU engagement** — best to engage early rather than have it raised as a blocker late
 - **Integration expectations** — brigades may expect more integration than initially offered; set expectations clearly
 - **Procurement timeline mismatch** — brigade procurement can take 12–18 months; don't promise faster
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10. Immediate Next Steps

1. Continue building up metrics on your own watch (time saved, errors avoided, audit log events)
 2. Create the one-page summary and 2-minute demo video
 3. Identify your first peer WC to pilot with
 4. Prepare the security/DPIA documentation
 5. Approach your SM informally with a demo (not a pitch)
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